

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Making Sense of the Exile

The kings and people of Israel repeatedly disobeyed God and failed to keep their special agreement (the covenant) with him. As a result, God announced that he would bring the covenant curses upon them (see Deuteronomy 28:15–68; compare Jeremiah 4:13; Amos 5:11; Micah 6:14–15). God sent the Assyrian and Babylonian armies to carry out this punishment, and many Israelites went into exile (see 2 Kings 24:1–25:21). They were forced to leave their land.

The exile of Israel influenced many psalms, impacting their images and themes.

In Psalm 89, the psalmist expresses the sadness, pain, and confusion the Israelites experienced when they were living in exile through questions:

- Has God abandoned David’s royal family line (89:38–39)?
- How long will God’s anger last (Psalm 89:46)?
- Does God understand human weakness (89:47–48)?
- Is God true to his nature (89:49)?
- Is God fair by not avenging his people (89:50–51)?

During and after the exile, God’s people had many questions. Some doubted God’s ability to rule. Instead of ignoring these doubts, wise readers listen, think about, and study the answers in Scripture.

The final answer came through the Lord Jesus Christ (see Isaiah 52–54; Luke 1:46–55, 67–79; 4:18–19; Romans 6:6, 16–23; Hebrews 12:22–24). Yet, those who lived during the exile could only partly imagine a hopeful future. They asked difficult questions and lived without clear answers.

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 26:27–45; Deuteronomy 28:36–37, 63–68; 30:1–5; 2 Kings 17:5–23; 24:1–25:21; Ezra 5:12; Psalms 89; 107; 126; Isaiah 5:13; 27:13; 52:1–12; 59:10; Jeremiah 2:37; 3:18; 4:13; Ezekiel 6:9; 20:41; 37:1–14; Amos 5:11; Micah 6:14–15

Marriage and Sexuality

Scripture considers marriage holy from the very beginning. Sexual expression is an important part of it (Genesis 2:23–25). The first human sin caused a disruption in all relationships. This first happened between God and humans, then between husband and wife, and even between humans and creation (Genesis 3). The division between Adam and Eve showed in their

sexuality. They could no longer be naked in the garden without feeling shame.

In Proverbs, the wise teacher often warns young men to avoid sexual temptations outside of marriage (Proverbs 2:16–22; 5:1–23; 6:20–7:27). While a young man might find other women attractive, acting on these temptations can have severe consequences. His family and career goals might become destroyed. Proverbs advises young men to build a strong relationship with their wives. The Scripture encourages men to have a healthy marital relationship instead of being with other women (5:15–20).

Although this section of Proverbs was first written to teach young men, everyone can think about these issues of marriage and sexuality. The book of Proverbs encourages everyone to recognize the holiness and beauty of marital love as God, the wise Creator, planned it.

The New Testament emphasizes the holiness of sexuality and its proper expression within marriage. Jesus refers to the creation story in Genesis to emphasize the intended permanence of marriage. After quoting Genesis 2:24, he says, “So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate” (Matthew 19:3–6). The apostle Paul talks about the importance of maintaining sexual intimacy in marriage to prevent temptation by Satan (1 Corinthians 7:3–5). God wants those who marry to stay faithful to each other and avoid harmful sexual activities that could damage their holy relationship (see Hebrews 13:4).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:18–25; Proverbs 2:16–22; 5:15–20; 6:20–35; 7:1–27; Jeremiah 5:7–11; Hosea 2:20; Malachi 2:14–16; Matthew 19:4–6; 22:30; 1 Corinthians 6:15–20; Hebrews 13:4

Material Reward

Some people in the Old Testament period believed that righteous people would usually prosper in material ways. They treated the wisdom sayings found in books like Proverbs as general rules for life. Other biblical books, such as Job and Ecclesiastes, challenge this view. When this belief is treated as a guarantee, it can lead to false guilt or blame when prosperity does not come, and to spiritual complacency when it does.

The suffering of Job serves as an example. His friends accepted a traditional theological view that said Job’s troubles were evidence against him (19:5). They claimed his suffering was punishment for his sin (4:7–9). They believed Job’s penalty was probably less than

he deserved (11:6). Yet, God's analysis of Job's life proved this idea false (42:7-8). God testified to his special relationship with Job and restored Job's good reputation as his servant.

Material well-being does not always conflict with spiritual blessings. Yet, when we see blessings as material gain, "the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth, and the desire for other things" often distract us from spiritual blessings (Mark 4:19; see also Luke 6:25). We can easily become greedy, envious, and lustful. Our self-worth might depend on what we own, even if we still owe money on it. This perspective is not Christian but reflects a worldly way of thinking (1 John 2:15-17).

In his suffering, Job went from complaining to showing humility. He recognized God's righteous power (Job 40:4-5; 42:2-6). We can also regard difficulties as chances for spiritual growth (James 1:2-4).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 13:2; 1 Kings 10:23; Job 4:7-9; 11:6; 19:5; Psalms 49:16-20; 73:1-28; Proverbs 14:20; 18:11; 28:11; Ecclesiastes 5:10-20; Jeremiah 17:11; Zephaniah 1:18; Matthew 27:57; Mark 4:19; 10:17-25; Luke 6:24-25; 16:10-31; 1 Timothy 6:17; James 1:2-4, 9; 5:1; 1 John 2:16; 3 John 1:2

The Message of Reconciliation

Reconciliation is a term found throughout the New Testament. It means making peace and repairing broken relationships. When two people reconcile, they stop being enemies and become friends again. In the same way, through Jesus, people can have their relationship with God restored.

In Romans 5:1-11, the apostle Paul focuses on the cost of God's reconciling work through the death of his son.

Colossians 1:15-20 is a hymn that praises Jesus Christ. It tells how he brings all of creation (everything in heaven and on earth) back into a right relationship with God. The passage shows that Jesus is Lord over all things that exist.

In Ephesians 2:11-22, the focus is on reconciliation that includes both Jews and non-Jews (gentiles). They form a united church with all opposition removed.

Paul explains reconciliation in detail when discussing the meaning of Jesus' death in 2 Corinthians 5:18-21. Earlier, Paul reminded the Corinthians about the importance of the cross (1 Corinthians 15:3-5). But he did not explain much about its meaning then. Now, he clarifies that Christ's death on the cross means Christ "became" sin so sinners could reconnect with God.

This reconciliation changes enemies into friends. The cost of this exchange is that "God made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21).

With Jesus' resurrection and his victory over death, a new world begins. In this new era, God's people have the promise of eternal union with him (see 2 Corinthians 4:14-5:10). Those who trust in Jesus for salvation receive the Holy Spirit, which guarantees future salvation (5:5). They know that God accepts them and will welcome them forever.

Those who have made peace with God should help others find their way back to him (2 Corinthians 5:18-21). Since Christians have experienced this peace, they should also try to restore their personal relationships (see Matthew 5:24; 18:15; Romans 12:18).

Passages for Further Study

Ezekiel 45:15; Daniel 9:24; Matthew 5:24; 18:15; Acts 10:36; Romans 5:1-2; 8:6-9, 15-16; 12:18; 15:13; 2 Corinthians 5:18-21; 13:11; Ephesians 2:11-18; Colossians 1:19-22; Hebrews 2:17

Messages Against the Nations

Why did Israel's prophets speak to nations who were unlikely to hear their messages? Why did the prophets care about these nations' thoughts and actions?

The real audience was God's people. These messages reminded them that God does not have a double standard. He judges the sins of his people and those of other nations. Judgment begins "with the family of God" (1 Peter 4:17).

But it does not stop there. God will judge everyone, both inside and outside Israel, who rebels against him. Everyone must recognize the Lord as the one true and sovereign God.

The people of Judah often trusted nations like Egypt to save them from foreign enemies. They did not realize that God used other nations to judge them. The prophets reminded the people that no nation on earth can replace God. In the end, all nations will bow before him in worship.

The messages against foreign nations reminded the covenant community that even though God judged them for their sins, they remained his precious people. The main accusation against these foreign nations was that they persecuted and insulted God's chosen people. This offended God. The negative part of God's covenant with Abraham was still active. God says he will "curse those who curse you" (Genesis 12:3).

God's main goal in history is to bring glory to himself. By exiling his sinful people and judging their arrogant oppressors, God showed his power and holiness. Despite the exile to Babylon, there was still hope for the positive side of the covenant to be fulfilled: "all the families of the earth will be blessed through you" (Genesis 12:3; see also Romans 11:1-27). God had not finished the plans for his people. He would ultimately glorify himself by returning them from the distant lands where he had scattered them.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:3; Deuteronomy 23:3-6; Isaiah 13:1-23:18; Jeremiah 25:29; 46:1-51:64; Ezekiel 9:6; 25:1-32:32; 36:23; 39:7; Daniel 4:17; Amos 1:1-2:3; 3:2; Obadiah 1:1-16; John 15:18-24; Acts 3:25-26; Romans 2:9-10; 11:1-27; Ephesians 1:3-14; 1 Peter 4:17; Revelation 18:1-24

The Messiah

The Greek word *christos* has the same meaning as the Hebrew word *mashiakh*. It means "anointed one" (or "chosen one"). Both words translate as "Messiah" or "Christ." In the Bible, the Messiah is someone chosen by God for a special purpose. In ancient times, people poured oil on a person's head to show that God had chosen them for an important task. This act was called anointing.

In Judaism, the term *messiah* had different meanings. The Old Testament refers to different people who received special anointing from God. God chose these people for different tasks and reasons. Not all of these people did good things, but God still selected them for his purposes (Exodus 28:41; 1 Samuel 9:16; 1 Kings 19:16; Isaiah 45:1).

The prophets expected a future Messiah who would begin God's kingdom (Daniel 9:25-26; Zechariah 9:9-10). During Jesus' time, many Jews expected the Messiah to be a political warrior. He would lead Israel to victory over its oppressors and restore Israel as an independent kingdom (see Psalms of Solomon 17-18).

Some Jews viewed the Messiah as a person who would come before the kingdom of God. The community at Qumran, where they found the Dead Sea Scrolls, expected a Messiah who would serve as both a priest and a political warrior.

Because of this confusion, it is not surprising that Jesus avoided the title. He taught his followers that he would suffer as Isaiah prophesied (Isaiah 52:13-53:12). The Jews interpreted this passage to refer to Israel. Jesus emphasized suffering and service as the path to victory (Matthew 16:21-28; 20:25-28). This was

opposite of the popular Jewish view of the Messiah as a royal conqueror. Yet, this was God's way of establishing his kingdom (see Luke 2:25-32; John 12:37-50; Acts 2:29-36).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 17:6; Exodus 28:41; 1 Samuel 9:16; Isaiah 52:13-53:12; Daniel 9:25-26; Zechariah 9:9-10; Matthew 2:4-6; 11:2-6; 16:13-20; 17:10-12; 22:41-46; 24:23-27; 26:62-65; Luke 2:8-11, 25-35; 3:15-18; 23:35-43; 24:26-27, 46-47; John 4:21-29; 7:25-27, 31, 40-43; 12:34-50; 20:30-31; Acts 2:22-36; 3:17-26; 4:25-28; 9:22; 13:23-25; 17:3; 26:22-23; 28:17-24

The Messianic Banquet

Through his teaching and miracles, Jesus showed that the messianic banquet was ready. The messianic banquet is a special feast that God promised to prepare when the Messiah came. He invited all people to come and receive God's salvation and become part of God's kingdom.

Jesus compared his ministry to a wedding feast, with himself as the groom (Luke 5:33-35). The kingdom of God was like a grand banquet. God invited everyone, but some chose not to attend (Luke 14:15-24; see also Matthew 8:11-12). Jesus often shared meals with a variety of people. This included disliked tax collectors and committed Pharisees (5:29-32; 7:36-50; 11:37-41; 14:1-6).

He also used the imagery of feasting and banquets in his teachings and parables (Luke 5:33-35; 12:35-38; 14:7-14, 15-24; 17:7-10; 22:28-30). Additionally, he fed large crowds with just a few loaves and fishes (9:10-17).

The Old Testament background for this feast imagery is Isaiah 25:6. It describes God's final salvation as a great feast for everyone: "the LORD of Hosts will prepare a lavish banquet for all the peoples, a feast of aged wine, of choice meat, of finely aged wine" (see also Isaiah 65:13-14).

Jesus' public ministry began the invitation to the banquet and its beginning. Through his death and resurrection, he brought salvation. Now, everyone can come to God's banquet table and receive the kingdom's spiritual blessings. Yet, this banquet will fully happen in the future kingdom. Then, Jesus' disciples will "eat and drink at My table in My kingdom" and "sit on thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Luke 22:30; see also Revelation 19:7-9).

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 25:6; 65:13-14; Luke 5:29-35; 6:21; 7:36-50; 9:10-17; 11:37-41; 12:35-40; 13:24-30; 14:1-24; 17:8; 22:30

Miracles

Miracles often happened in the Bible. They were especially common during the time of Moses and the ministries of Elijah, Elisha, Jesus, and his apostles. The Bible does not try to prove miracles. It just reports them. Miracles show God's power over creation and his compassion for human needs.

Miracles can lead people to believe in God (John 2:23). But true belief requires more than just witnessing a miracle (see John 12:37). Miracles remind us that anything is possible for God (Mark 9:21–23; compare Matthew 19:26; Mark 10:27; Luke 1:37; 18:27).

Jesus performed many miracles during his ministry, including healing the sick, casting out demons, controlling nature, and resurrecting the dead. He showed deep love for people by meeting their needs. Many followed him because of these miracles (John 6:2). Yet, he warned against following him only for the miracles (John 6:26).

The three greatest miracles related to Jesus are:

1. His arrival as “the Word” of God in human flesh (John 1:14).
2. His resurrection from the dead (Matthews 28; Mark 16:1–8; Luke 24:1–53; John 20:1–31; Acts 1:3; 1 Corinthians 15:3–8; see also Acts 23:6; 26:8).
3. The miracle of spiritual rebirth (John 3:3–8; Galatians 2:20; Ephesians 2:8–10).

Jesus came into the world to save it and to die for sins, showing God's great love for humanity (John 3:16; Romans 5:8; 8:32; Ephesians 2:4–5; 1 John 3:1–2). God resurrecting Jesus from the dead shows his power over death and gives us hope for eternal life (1 Peter 1:3–9). Anyone who trusts in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord is reborn as a child of God and receives eternal life (John 1:12; 3:36; Romans 5:1–2; 1 John 5:11–13).

The miraculous work of Jesus continued through his followers, as shown in the book of Acts (for example, Acts 3:1–11; 5:12–15; 6:8; 8:6–7; 9:32–42; 14:3). Filled with the Holy Spirit, the apostles and other Christian leaders performed these miracles to show the power and truth of the Christian message (14:3; see John 3:2; Hebrews 2:4).

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 19:23–26; 28:1–20; Mark 10:23–27; Luke 1:30–38; 18:24–27; 24:1–53; John 1:12–14; 3:2–8, 16; 20:1–21:25; Acts 4:29–31; 5:12–16; 6:8; 8:4–23; 9:32–42; 14:3–4; 26:8; Romans 5:1, 8; 8:32; Ephesians 2:4–5, 8–10; Hebrews 2:4; 1 Peter 1:3–5; 1 John 5:12–13

Miraculous Signs in the Gospel of John

The Gospels use three words to describe Jesus' miraculous works. In Matthew, Mark, and Luke, the Greek word *dunamis* means “power.” It describes an act of raw force that amazes people and makes them realize that God is working through Jesus (see Mark 6:2).

The apostle John does not use the popular term *dunamis* for Jesus' miracles. Instead, he calls each miracle a “sign” (Greek *sēmeion*). This means an event with deeper significance. John also refers to Jesus' miracles as “works” (Greek *erga*, see John 10:38; 7:3; 9:3). Jesus' miracles were part of the work God gave him to do to show the Father to the world (17:4).

John's Gospel records seven miraculous signs during Jesus' ministry:

1. Jesus changed water into wine (John 2:1–11).
2. Jesus healed an official's son (4:46–54).
3. Jesus healed a paralyzed man (5:1–17).
4. Jesus fed five thousand people (6:1–15).
5. Jesus walked on water (6:16–21).
6. Jesus healed a blind man (9:1–41).
7. Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead (11:1–44).

John also notes a miraculous catch of fish after Jesus' resurrection (John 21:4–14). Most of these signs led people to trust in Christ (2:11; 4:53; 11:45–48).

Yet, Jesus' goals went beyond the signs. The miraculous signs were like road markers. They pointed to a greater truth. A miraculous sign often comes with a talk from Jesus, explaining the truth it reveals.

For example, Jesus fed the five thousand men, not just to meet their physical needs. But he showed that he is “the bread of life.” He would give himself for them when he died on the cross (John 6:35; 6:51).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 4:8–31; 7:3; Numbers 14:11, 22; Deuteronomy 4:34; Psalms 74:9; 78:43; Matthew 12:38–39; John 2:1–11, 18, 23; 3:2; 4:48, 54; 6:2, 14, 26, 30; 7:31; 9:16; 10:41; 11:47; 12:18, 37; 15:24; 20:30; Acts 2:43; 4:16, 22, 30; 5:12; 8:6; 14:3; 15:12; Romans 15:19

Misunderstanding in the Gospel of John

In John's Gospel, people often misunderstood Jesus (see John 3:4; 4:11, 33; 7:35; 11:12–13). They disagreed about who Jesus was. When they realized what he truly meant, some wanted to arrest him, while others wanted to follow him (7:40–44). Only later, after the disciples received the Holy Spirit, did they fully understand his importance (see 16:12–13).

The world remains in spiritual darkness and struggles to understand life or God (John 1:5, 10). People cannot understand God's messages on their own unless God helps them understand. God's spiritual light enters the darkness, revealing the world's flaws. Many people retreat further into spiritual darkness because they prefer it over the light (3:19–20). Only God's Spirit can transform and help people see plainly as God's children do (3:21; 8:12; 12:35–36, 46).

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 6:8–13; 56:10–11; Matthew 13:11–17; John 1:10–11; 3:19–20; John 7:32–36; 9:40–41; 12:40; Romans 1:21; 2 Corinthians 3:13–18; 4:3–4; 1 John 2:9–11; Revelation 3:17

Music in Ancient Israel

The earliest people who moved from place to place (called nomads) made music. The first musician mentioned in the Bible is “Jubal,” who played the harp and flute (Genesis 4:21).

Music was important from the beginning of Israel's worship in the tabernacle. In Exodus 28:34–35, Aaron's robe had bells on the lower hem that sounded as he entered the holy place. Scripture records several songs created by God's people (for example, Exodus 15:1–21; Deuteronomy 31:30–32:44; Judges 5:1–31).

The first liturgical music in the Old Testament appears during the transfer of the ark of the covenant. King David and the Israelites sang, played instruments, and danced to honor the Lord (2 Samuel 6:5). David is famous for creating the musical instruments used in the temple (2 Chronicles 7:6). In the time after the exile (when the people of Israel returned from being captives in Babylon), the singers from the tribe of Levi were descendants of Asaph. Asaph was the chief musician appointed by David (Ezra 2:41; Nehemiah 7:44; 11:22–23). In simple terms, Israel's worship music and how it was organized began during the time of David.

The formal ceremonies in Solomon's Temple were different from the excited and spontaneous worship of David's time (2 Chronicles 7:1–6). Singers and musicians for temple worship were chosen from the tribe of Levi (1 Chronicles 25:1, 7). These musicians took turns participating in services held on weekdays, Sabbaths, and special holy days.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 4:21; Exodus 28:34–35; 2 Samuel 6:5; 2 Chronicles 7:6; Psalm 71:22–23

The Mystery of the Good News

In his letters, the apostle Paul often uses the word mystery to describe the good news about Jesus (some translations use the word secret). Sometimes, Paul uses mystery as a way of referring to the good news itself (Colossians 2:2; 4:3; 1 Corinthians 2:1; Ephesians 1:9; 6:19). Often, as in Colossians 1:26, Paul says, it is “the mystery that was hidden for ages and generations but is now revealed” (see also Romans 16:25; 1 Corinthians 2:7; Ephesians 3:9). Paul does not mean the good news is a mystery that has to be investigated. He also does not mean the good news is a Gnostic idea that only a few people can understand. (Gnostics emphasized special secret knowledge as the key to salvation.)

Instead, Paul adapts the term from Jewish apocalyptic teaching. The term apocalyptic comes from a Greek word meaning “uncovering” or “revelation.” This is the same word that gives the book of Revelation its name. In the apocalyptic view, God has already created a plan for all of history. This plan exists in God's mind but remains hidden from humans until God chooses to reveal it. For Paul, this secret plan has now been shown to everyone through Christ. It is now being shared throughout the world by his apostles.

In the Old Testament, prophets shared parts of the good news, but God kept some details hidden until the New Testament. These include:

- the full participation of gentiles (non-Jewish people) as fellow heirs with Jews (Colossians 1:27; Ephesians 3:1–9);
- the indwelling of Jesus Christ in believers (Colossians 1:27; 2:2); and
- the union of Christ and his church (this union is shown or illustrated by the union of husband and wife (Ephesians 5:32).

Some parts of God's plan remain hidden and will be revealed in the future, such as:

- the salvation of all Israel (Romans 11:25–27); and
- Christians will be transformed when Jesus returns (1 Corinthians 15:51–53).

Passages for Further Study

Romans 11:25; 16:25; 1 Corinthians 2:1, 7; 15:51; Ephesians 1:9; 3:1–9; 5:32; 6:19; Colossians 1:26–27; 2:2; 4:3